OTT

Period Drama

Ram Madhvani's SonyLIV series **The Waking of a Nation** *uses the courtroom drama and investigative procedural tropes to depict the lead up to the Jallianwala Bagh massacre*

In 2017, INDIA TODAY roped in Ram Madhvani to direct a short, *This Bloody Line*, for its 'India Tomorrow' series. Premiered at the India Today Conclave in Mumbai, it instantly struck a chord for its subtle, affecting reminder of how the Radcliffe Line ripped the Indian subcontinent apart and sowed seeds of discord from which people still reel.

Seated in his office in Famous Studios, Madhvani says the experience of making the short lit a spark to relook at seminal moments from the British colonisation of India. "It was the most personal thing somebody had asked me to make," he recalls. "Since then, I have been trying to figure out how to speak about all that bothers us—racism and prejudice, cultural colonialism and the white man's burden." The result is the SonyLIV series *The Waking of a Nation*, which through the prism of a courtroom drama and an investigative procedural follows the sequence of events that led to the Jallianwala Bagh massacre in 1919.

More than the tragedy itself, Madhvani focuses on the lesser-shown Hunter Commission a.k.a. the Punjab Disorders Committee—comprising five Britishers and three Indians—which was set up to investigate the event that shook the nation and provided fresh ammo to the independence movement.

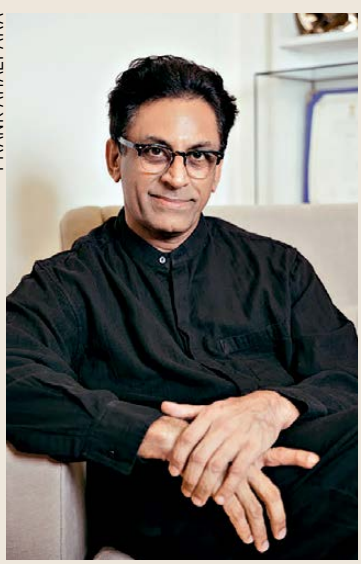
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Research entailed relying on the commission's findings documented in bulky reports and turning to the work of researchers in Amritsar, New Delhi, Ludhiana and London to paint an authentic portrait. Madhvani deploys a found-footage feel by way of black-and-white portraits and identification documents and freezing frames of the action.

Even as Madhvani aims for "a certain realism", he speaks of his fondness for "faction" and practitioners of new journalism like Hunter S. Thompson and Tom Wolfe. For the show, Madhvani along with his two co-writers revolves the story around three friends—Hari, Allahbaksh and Kanti—and "a strong woman", a vital component of his work, to spike up



RETELLING HISTORY
A still from *The Waking of a Nation;* (below) show creator & director Ram Madhvani



FRANK AHALPARA